

he says.

It wasn't just a superficial influence. Hardik says he tried to emulate every aspect of Sardar's attitude.

"When I got the chance to see him and later play with him for the same team in 2016, I learnt a lot. I understood how important the work one did off the field was. I saw how careful he was with his diet, sleeping pattern and hydration. He looked at every small detail that made him a better player. Sardar *bhai* retired just as I was getting into the Indian team, so when I got the chance to wear his jersey, of course, I took it. I think the No. 8 jersey has a lot of importance in the Indian team because Sardar has set a very good example. I hope I'm living up to that example. So, I want this number to inspire the next set of youngsters — because that was the same number that inspired me," says Hardik.

While Hardik did get to be a part of the Indian team with the jersey he wanted, in the same central position as Sardar, it took a while for him to truly own his idol's number.

"It wasn't that I wasn't working hard. It was just that the results were not coming right away. It was only after the Tokyo Olympics that I actually started earning a name, but it's all the work that I put in starting in 2018 when I made my debut, and 2021 when I actually got the chance to put everything together. Everyone only sees that in 2021, but it's the invisible hard work that actually made it possible," he says.

Having done the hard work himself, Hardik has a clear idea of what it takes to be part of the Indian team.

"There are two ways you can make your place in the Indian team," says Hardik. "You can either be really versatile, like someone like Sumit. He can play every side — on the right, in the attack, or in midfield. You can put him in any position and he will fit right in. The other way you can be part of the team is if you are irreplaceable in any one position. Amit (Rohidas) is the best first rusher we have when we are defending penalty corners, so he always has a



place. We know Harmanpreet is the best drag-flicker, so we will always need him. With Harman, I have to inject the ball. So that's one of the roles that I try to be strong in," he says.

Unique role

Injecting the ball to the drag-flicker isn't the most glamorous role, but Hardik says he enjoys it.

"I actually wanted to be a drag-flicker like my uncle (Jugraj Singh), but I found out very quickly that I'm not good at that. As a junior, I started injecting the ball and, since Sardar Singh used to inject the ball also, it was even more of a skill I wanted to be good at. I really started focusing on it in my junior year and once I got into the senior team, I formed a really good partnership with Harmanpreet," he says.

That pairing has combined to score many goals for India, but Hardik admits he was the weak link early on.

"When I think about the Tokyo Olympics, I feel really bad because I sent so many really bumpy balls to Harman in the penalty corners. Despite that, he really managed to convert so many of them. I'll always be grateful for that," he says.

Winning bronze at Tokyo might

Olympic pride: Indian hockey team vice-captain Hardik Singh shares a proud moment with his parents at their Jalandhar home, as they hold his back-to-back Olympic bronze medals from Tokyo and Paris — a symbol of grit, legacy, and dreams fulfilled.

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have been the professional turning point of the then 22-year-old's career, but he tries to view it objectively.

"I played in the Olympics when I was really young, but in our team there was Shamsher (Singh), who had just four caps when he came into the Olympic team, and there was Sreejesh, who had over 300 caps before he got his medal. Everyone's journey is different, but the only thing that matters is whether you enjoy every bit of preparing for the actual game," he says.

Indeed, after the initial excitement of winning the medal faded, Hardik says he realised he was still unsatisfied.

"We didn't have any medal for 41 years, so at first I was just really happy when we beat Germany and got the bronze. But then I saw the final between Australia and Belgium. And then I saw just how the Belgian team celebrated when they won. It